

4-3 1st
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2000 - 79

CFO-ORC FILE _____

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD _____

Recd 12/8/00 wpl

Species: Black-billed Cuckoo (*Coccyzus erythrophthalmus*)

Date: 11 June 2000

Number seen: one

Sex: ?

Plumage: Basic

Locality: Along Blue River at 1 Rd.

Elevation: ~7400'

Nearest town: Kremmling

County: Grand

Time observed: about 09:00 MDT

Duration of observation: total of about 15 seconds

Description: While on a Big Day with Sue Bonfield and Paul Hurtado, we stopped at the 1 Rd. crossing of the Blue River south of Kremmling just to see what we could see (a cardinal sin on Big Days, I realize, but...). Immediately after we got out of the car, I noticed a bird leaving the trees on the southeast corner of the crossing and immediately knew it for a cuckoo. I yelled out to the others and we all saw it reasonably well, though only in flight, as it landed deep in another tree on the north side of the road on private property. When I first saw it, I immediately looked for rufous in the wings and couldn't find any. I tried to see the bill color, but by that time the view wasn't the best, but I did note the overall pattern of dark and light on head and bill. I never saw the underside of the tail, unfortunately, but I did note the pattern of the underwing. We called it a Yellow-billed (YBCU) at the time and we were quite happy about that as it is not an easy Big Day bird. However, I ruminated over it the rest of the day, as I've seen 100s of Yellow-bills and I can always see the rufous in the wings given that kind of look. So, the next morning, I wrote notes on the bird from memory and then checked the National Geographic field guide, which, of course, confirmed my suspicions that the bird was, indeed, a Black-billed (BBCU)

The bird was an obvious cuckoo (long, slender body, long tail with white tips to the rectrices, long, angled wings, brown above, white below) and in the reasonable light at first sighting was the same brown color on the entire upperparts. I could detect no rufous at the bases of the remiges. The entire underparts were white. The head was half brown, half white, with the meeting of the two running through the middle of the head to the bottom of the base of the bill. The tail was, as far as I could tell, entirely the same brown color as the back, with white tips to the individual rectrices - I didn't note the size of the spots. There was no strong pattern to the underwings, they just seemed to get darker from the whitish wing linings to the dark remiges.

Similar species eliminated by description: The only similar species are other *Coccyzus* cuckoos. YBCU is eliminated by the head pattern, as the dark/white meeting on the head in that species hits the bill above the gape. Additionally, YBCU shows a strong pattern of white/rufous on the underside of the wings and has blackish outer tail feathers that are often visible in flight. And, finally, YBCU has rufous flashes in the upperwings created by rufous bases to most of the remiges, particularly the primaries. Mangrove Cuckoo, which in some respects is more like BBCU than YBCU, is readily eliminated by the same head pattern as for YBCU and by the underparts coloration. Dark-billed Cuckoo (an austral migrant from South America with one record from Texas and a couple from Middle America) has a dark bill like that of BBCU, but its underparts are more like that of Mangrove.

An interesting note: The only previous Grand Co. record is from almost the same location.

duration): I heard none.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen 100s of YBCUs, >65 BBCUs, and four Mangrove Cuckoos. I have seen no Dark-billed Cuckoos.

Light conditions: sun to my right and behind me initially, but then as the bird flew NE, in front of me

Optical equipment used: Zeiss 7x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at 30 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Sue Bonfield, Paul Hurtado

Other observers who saw the bird independently: none

If photographed, type of equipment and film: Photo submitted (Nikon and Fujichrome)

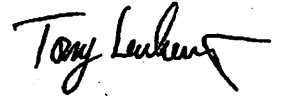
List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: Nat. Geo. 3rd ed.

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road,

Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: This report was written on 6 December 2000 from notes written about 24 hours after the sighting.